



HOMEOWNER Valerie Elachi searches for valuables amid the rubble of her home in Altadena after it was destroyed by the Eaton fire. ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

Did lack of cityhood hurt Altadena?

In the first 24 hours of the Eaton fire, Pasadena's communications director helped activate four different kinds of alerts to keep its residents apprised of evacuation orders, while also hopping on several news programs and doing interviews to share updates in real time.

Some wonder if unincorporated status had a role in slow evacuation alerts that led to ‘catastrophic failure’

By Grace Toohey

Further east, when Arcadia joined the sphere of concern as the fire erratically tore through the San Gabriel foothills, the city's fire chief successfully advocated for unified commanders to issue more widespread evacuations than initially proposed.

[See Altadena, A10]

Monumental fire debris cleanup could finish in June

By JAMES RAINEY

A small army of laborers, heavy-equipment operators, hazmat technicians and truck drivers have cleared more than a third of the home lots left in charred ruin by January's firestorms — a frenetic

pace that suggests the bulk of the vast government-run cleanup in Los Angeles County could be completed as early as June, officials say.

U.S. Army Corps of Engineers officers overseeing the effort said the crews of mostly private contractors are working at a record clip for a wildfire recovery, clearing nearly 120

lots a day and operating at close to the capacity that roads — and residents close to the fire zones — can tolerate.

The scope of the unfinished work came into clearer focus last week, with the passing of the April 15 deadline for residents of Altadena, Pacific Palisades and Malibu to opt

in or out of the cleanup.

Some 10,373 property owners completed “right-of-entry” forms authorizing the Army Corps and government contractors to work on their properties, while 1,698 others opted out of the program, many because they wanted their own crews

[See Debris, A11]

Jewelry owners catch gold fever as price of metal soars

Many are looking to melt their baubles for cash

By ANDREA CHANG

With gold prices at record highs, jewelry collectors are in meltdown mode.

For weeks, they've been scouring their homes and cracking open their safes to retrieve vintage necklaces, family heirlooms and other

expensive pieces containing the precious metal that can be melted for cash.

“It happens with every gold spike,” said Jeff Clark, a market analyst and founder of TheGoldAdvisor.com. “If you've got a lot of old gold jewelry, it's basically free money.”

The price of gold hit an

all-time high of \$3,357 per ounce on Thursday and is up about 27% from the beginning of the year, driven by factors including geopolitical tensions, tariff turmoil and increased demand from central banks.

Gold has long been considered a safe-haven asset

[See Gold, A9]



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

JEWELER Olivia Kazanjian recently persuaded a client to save items with irreplaceable craftsmanship.

State workers cash in on unused time off: Dentist got \$1.2 million

By MELODY GUTIERREZ

SACRAMENTO — When the state of California paid prison supervising dentist George Soohoo \$1.2 million last year, it wasn't for a job well done. It was for vacation never taken.

Soohoo joined the rare club of state employee mil-

lionaires by cashing out thousands of hours of unused time off when he retired, setting a new record for the payouts. He topped a list of nearly 1,000 workers who left state service last year with \$100,000 or more in banked leave benefits, a Los Angeles Times analysis of state payroll records found. In all, California paid

departing workers \$413 million last year for unused time off.

That's nothing compared with the massive financial liability the state faces for the banked time off still on the books, alarming government watchdog groups.

“I'm more disturbed than I am surprised,” said John

[See Payouts, A8]

Ukraine skeptical of Easter ceasefire

Putin announces temporary pause in fighting as Moscow and Kyiv exchange prisoners. **WORLD, A3**

More anti-Trump protests in U.S.

Rallies in many cities decry perceived constitutional and civil rights violations. **NATION, A6**

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 74/54. **B10**

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Lee is likely to be Oakland mayor

Ex-congresswoman's rival Taylor concedes, though vote count is not yet final. **CALIFORNIA, B2**

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